

Sally's happy because she thinks Frederick's making good cash. She envisions a comfortable future for herself, if not a downright luxurious one. Frederick's earning potential seems limitless because he's so talented. But here's what Sally doesn't know: Frederick has a \$100,000 student loan, he's financed that fancy car he drives her around in, and he puts all those gourmet meals he treats her to on a credit card that carries a five-figure balance. Sally's marrying an *idea of Frederick*, because the real Frederick isn't showing through . . . yet.

Sally, on the other hand, with her modest teaching salary, no debt, and a condo with some healthy equity, actually has more worth than Frederick. In fact, *he* is lucky to be marrying *her*! And if Sally's not careful, those dreams of Costa Rican vacations and private school for the kids will morph into a stress-filled, debt-ridden, house-poor reality. Now, Sally is no dummy. Her gut is telling her something is not quite right, so she wants to talk to Frederick about money issues. But it seems that every time she raises the topic, Frederick gets angry. And whenever he gets angry, he goes out on a spending spree.

I know another couple who have a notoriously rocky relationship. Every time there's a problem, one of them heads to Neiman Marcus to rack up thousands of dollars in clothing expenses and the other one secretly buys high-end consumer products in retaliation. They use money as a way to communicate to each other what they feel they're worth. Expensive gifts are sometimes given in lieu of real intimacy and real communication.

Remember, the most important financial decision you'll ever make is who you'll marry. Not because of the money you both bring to the partnership, but because of the attitudes, outlook, honesty, career potential, and any number of other factors that determine compatibility. Divorce is expensive, so if you get any of this stuff wrong, you're looking at a potential depletion of wealth. Especially if your financial value systems don't line up with your partner's. No amount of love or sexual compatibility will make up for it. Your relationship is toast. This is why sidelining money discussions before marriage, *at any income level*, is dangerous. And prenuptial arrangements can go a long way toward exposing and sometimes amending these issues.